

Hollywood introduces **widescreen** cinema and gimmicks such as **3D** to counter the growing medium of television.

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1950

Billy Wilder directs *Sunset Boulevard*, a controversial satire on the Hollywood system; **Bette Davis** lands her sharpest role in *All About Eve*.

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1950

A Streetcar Named Desire, directed by Elia Kazan, catapults a young **Marlon Brando** to movie superstardom.

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1951

Fred Zinnemann's *From Here to Eternity*, based on James Jones's epic novel of military life, sweeps eight Academy Awards.

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1953

1950
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Akira Kurosawa's *Rashomon* tells a crime story from four **different viewpoints**, a template that would be imitated in many movies.

1951
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The Day the Earth Stood Still is the first of many **science-fiction** movies that reflect widespread fears about the **Cold War**.

1952
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US judges rule that movies are a form of **free speech**: Roberto Rossellini's *L'Amore* cannot be banned for "sacrilege."

1953
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With the success of the thriller *The Wages of Fear*, director **Henri-Georges Clouzot** is dubbed the "French Hitchcock."

This chapter covers the shortest time period of any in the book—the 10 years between 1950 and 1959. Yet in that one decade we find a swathe of extraordinary movies. Many, as before, are American movies produced in Hollywood (which, by this period, had enough of a history to inspire the Tinseltown satire *Sunset Boulevard*), but great cinema was also rising to prominence in other parts of the world.

In the years that followed World War I, it had been Germany that blazed the trail of cinematic innovation. Now, after World War II, it was the turn of Japan.

Rise of Japan

In 1950, Akira Kurosawa released *Rashomon*, a fractured, brilliant story of a murder in ancient Japan.

The movie's impact was sudden and immense: not only did it make Kurosawa's name as a director, but it sparked a growing curiosity in the West toward international cinema. Also from Japan came the finely drawn, deceptively simple dramas of Yasujiro Ozu. And of course, there was *Godzilla*, whose towering monstrosity was inspired by Japan's direct experience of nuclear war, still raw in the national memory.

Cold War dread

Many movies of the 1950s provided the most delirious form of popular entertainment (even today, it's impossible for anyone to watch *Singin' in the Rain* without a grin on their face), and yet some of the key movies of this period also reflected anxieties over the Cold War and are

imbued with an existential dread. In *The Wages of Fear* (1953), a movie about a group of desperate men driving truckloads of nitroglycerine through rough country, French director Henri-Georges Clouzot made what was probably the most tense movie since *Battleship Potemkin* (1925). It was also a biting satirical story of imperialism, capitalism, and human greed.

In several countries, directors were creating movies that offered at once entertainment, intellectual stimulation, and stunning displays of technique. Douglas Sirk, for example, made lush melodramas about suburban American life, such as *All That Heaven Allows* (1955). Long dismissed as kitsch, they are now recognized as sensitive, multilayered masterpieces. In France, meanwhile, a group of